SETTING THE LAND RECORD STRAIGHT

The Congress government's Bhu Bharati reforms promise to bring transparency and efficiency in Telangana's land record management that the previous Dharani portal had failed to do

By Amarnath K. Menon



ANI

For over a century, Bhutharaju Jangaih's forefathers had cultivated two acres of inam land that the erstwhile jagirdars had gifted his ancestors. In 2020, the revenue divisional officer had issued the 56-year-old Jangaih an Occupation Rights Certificate (ORC) for over one-tenth of an acre of that land in Yacharam village in Telangana's Ranga Reddy district. But the Dharani portal—launched by the previous Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) government the same year—had left him in limbo, for it had no provision to issue a *patta* (land title right with passbook) to someone with an ORC. Now, with the passage of the Telangana Bhu Bharati (Record of Rights in Land) Bill, 2024, Jangaih—and thousands like him across 12 occupancy categories—are hopeful of finally getting their ownership rights.

The new law, which awaits the governor's assent after getting the legislative assembly's nod on December 20, seeks to streamline the state's land record management system, overhauling the now beleaguered Dharani portal that, ironically, was introduced for the very same purpose. Key reforms include the introduction of unique identification numbers for each land parcel, simplification of user interactions, decentralisation of dispute resolution and enhanced data security. With the transfer of the portal's operations to the National Informatics Centre (NIC) and the incorporation of mandatory survey maps into the records, the A. Revanth Reddy-led Congress government has underscored its commitment to fulfil the pre-2023 assembly poll promise of a holistic overhaul.

To begin with, the new legislation will introduce a new portal, Bhumata, to replace the older avatar, Dharani. Launched under the Telangana Rights in Land and Pattadar Pass Books Act, 2020, popularly known as the Record of Rights Act, Dharani had in the past four years become a symbol of bureaucratic inefficiency and alleged malpractices that left lakhs of landowners like Jangaih running from pillar to post. Over 924,000 title deed applications remain pending, 2.72 million acres of land are placed on a prohibited list that bar any transaction, and transactions for another 1.83 million acres are on hold due to incomplete digital signatures—thus paralysing legitimate ownership rights. With the new law, Revanth Reddy has promised to usher in a paradigm shift in transparency, efficiency and accessibility even as the state agencies probe the allegations of fraudulent deals and illegal sales of even Bhoodan land (donated to the landless poor or for community purposes).